

Self-report measures of well-being

How is well-being defined?

There is no consensus around a single definition of well-being, but there is general agreement that at minimum, well-being includes the presence of positive emotions and moods (e.g., contentment, happiness), the absence of negative emotions (e.g., depression, anxiety), satisfaction with life, fulfillment and positive functioning. In simple terms, well-being can be described as judging life positively and feeling good.

Well-being is a positive outcome that is meaningful for people and for many sectors of society, because it tells us that people perceive that their lives are going well. Well-being generally includes global judgments of life satisfaction and feelings ranging from depression to joy.

For public health purposes, physical well-being (e.g., feeling very healthy and full of energy) is also viewed as critical to overall well-being. Researchers from different disciplines have examined different aspects of well-being that include the following:

- Physical well-being.
- Economic well-being.
- Social well-being.
- Development and activity.
- Emotional well-being.
- Psychological well-being.
- Life satisfaction.
- Domain specific satisfaction.
- Engaging activities and work.
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How is well-being measured?

Because well-being is subjective, it is typically measured with self-reports. Self-reported measures are measures in which respondents are asked to report directly on their own behaviors, beliefs, attitudes, or intentions. For example, many common measures of attitudes such as Thurstone scales, Likert scales, and survey reports are self-report. Similarly, other constructs of interest are often measured via self-reports.

Self-reported measures can be contrasted to other types of measures that do not rely on respondents' reports. For example, behavioral measures involve observing respondents' behaviors, sometimes in a constrained or controlled environment. Similarly, physiological measures like galvanic skin response, pupillary response, and subtle movements of facial muscles rely on biological responses rather than self-report. Measures of other variables, such as weight, height, or cholesterol level

The earlier survey questionnaires were simplistic concerning single question about happiness and life satisfaction of the people. The scores obtained from these questions about the overall evaluation of people's life were found to be well converged (Andrew & Withey, 1976).

Over the time, the multi-item scales were developed. These multi-item scales had greater validity and reliability as compared to the single-item scales. Factors like life satisfaction, pleasant affect, unpleasant affect and self-esteem were found to be distinct from each other by Lucas, Diener & Suh (1996).

4 Scales, Questionnaires, and Tests Measuring Subjective Wellbeing

The **cognitive and affective** components (life satisfaction and happiness) of SWB are assessed using different scales and measures. These often **involve** self-report instruments **but** can also be evaluated by comparing the results with other variables (Layard, 2010):

Friends' reports

Probable wellbeing causes

Some likely wellbeing outcomes

An individual's physical functioning, e.g., cortisol levels

Brain activity measures

Scales measuring affect

1. Positive and Negative Affect Scale (PANAS)

The PANAS is a self-report questionnaire comprising two separate subscales, one measuring positive affect and one measuring negative affect (Watson, Clark, & Tellegen, 1988; Medvedev & Landhuis, 2018).

Each scale includes 10 adjectives that relate to different affective states, such as "hostile," "alert," "jittery(nervous)," and "proud." Using a 5-point Likert scale, where 1 is "Not at all/Very Slightly" and 5 is "Extremely," participants rate the extent to which they feel each emotion.

Read more about the PANAS in greater depth.

2. Scale of Positive and Negative Experience (SPANE)

Another commonly used measure of affect, the SPANE, was developed by Diener et al. in 2009. It measures both pleasant and unpleasant emotional feelings, as well as other positive states, such as flow and engagement, physical pleasure, and

interest. Similar to the PANAS, it works by presenting 12 adjectives that the participant considers; examples include "joyful," "afraid," and "contented."

All items are scored using a 5-point Likert scale that spans from 1 ("very rarely or never") to 5 ("very often or always"). The positive feelings score (SPANE-P) and negative feelings score (SPANE-N) yield positive and negative figures, respectively, which allows you to calculate your overall affect balance score (SPANE-B).

Your SPANE-B will be a figure between -24 (the unhappiest possible score) and 24 (the happiest possible rating). Find the Scale of Positive and Negative Experience in our [Positive Psychology Toolkit](#)©.

Scales measuring life satisfaction

1. Satisfaction With Life Scale

The Satisfaction With Life Scale (SWLS) was first created by researchers Diener, Emmons, Larsen, and Griffin (1985).

The scale was developed as a way to assess an individual's cognitive judgment of their satisfaction with their life as a whole.

It looks specifically at the life satisfaction construct and doesn't include items for affect. SWLS is a very simple, short questionnaire made up of only five statements. Participants completing the questionnaire are asked to judge how they feel about each of the statements using a seven-point scoring system, with 1 being "strongly disagree" and 7 being "strongly agree," **A higher score indicates higher life satisfaction.**

Below, I've outlined what these **statements are:**

1. In most ways, my life is close to my ideal.
2. The conditions of my life are excellent.
3. I am satisfied with my life.
4. So far, I have gotten the important things I want in life.
5. If I could live my life over, I would change almost nothing.

The SWLS is not designed to help you understand satisfaction in any one specific domain of life, such as your job or relationships; instead, it has been developed to help you get a sense of your satisfaction with your life as a whole.

How Does the Scoring Work?

The scoring for the SWLS works quite simply, by adding up the total of the numbers you score against each of the statements. So, remembering that **1**= strongly disagree and **7** = strongly agree, the higher your score, the higher your sense of life satisfaction as a whole.

As a guide, your total score means:

- 31–35 = Extremely satisfied
- 26–30 = Satisfied
- 21–25 = Slightly satisfied
- 20 = Neutral
- 15–19 = Slightly dissatisfied
- 10–14 = Dissatisfied
- 5–9 = Extremely dissatisfied

Pavot and Diener (2013) created a more in-depth description of what your score means for your sense of life satisfaction. Very briefly, we've written up what they had to say, but it's worth accessing the original documents.

- *31–35 Extremely satisfied*

If you score this high on the SWLS, it means you have a strong love of your life and feel that things are going really well for you. This does not mean to say that you feel your life is perfect, but you are content with how things are and/or feel any challenges are temporary and can be managed.

A high score does not indicate that you are complacent about your sense of satisfaction, and it is likely you understand that challenge is a pathway to growth and greater satisfaction.

- *26–30 Satisfied*

If you score in this range, you likely feel that most things in your life are going really well, but there may be one or two key areas you wish to change. You understand that your life is not perfect and respect that any challenges are also an area for further growth and exploration.

- *21–25 Slightly satisfied*

If you score in this margin, you're in good company. The researchers assert that this is where the majority of people score themselves. This score means you are generally satisfied, on an average day-to-day basis; however, there are areas you'd really like to improve.

Rather than there being one or two things that you feel would give you greater satisfaction, you might feel that small improvements across all domains of your life would lead to a higher sense of life satisfaction.

- *20 Neutral*

A score of 20 – bang in the middle of the scale – means you're likely pretty neutral about your sense of satisfaction about your life. You might not give too much thought to what does or doesn't need improving, and you're quite content where you are.

- *15–19 Slightly dissatisfied*

A score in this range might mean that you tend to feel dissatisfied more than satisfied on a day-to-day basis, and there are several significant areas for improvement. It might also indicate that you're generally content, but there is one area of life where you feel deeply unsatisfied, which is creating a lower score.

A score in this margin requires further thought and reflection on where improvements need to be made to increase your sense of satisfaction.

- *10–14 Dissatisfied*

A dissatisfied score tends to mean you're feeling substantially dissatisfied about your current circumstances. This might be deep dissatisfaction across all areas of life or that two or three areas are far worse than the others.

It's worth reflecting to see if your dissatisfaction is due to a recent event or situation, which may be temporary, or if this is a chronic experience because you are not living the life you truly want.

- *5–9 Extremely dissatisfied*

As you may have guessed, a score at the very low end of the scale means that you are extremely dissatisfied with your current life circumstances. Again, if this score is due to a recent hard blow in life, such as bereavement, then things may get better over time with the right support.

However, a score this low tends to be an indication of dissatisfaction across multiple areas of life and is a good starting point to begin reflecting on why that might be.

2. Oxford Happiness Questionnaire (OHQ)

Hills and Argyle (2002) developed the OHQ as an improvement on the Oxford Happiness Inventory, which was being used at the time to measure SWB (Kashdan, 2004). The Oxford Happiness

Questionnaire, designed to measure individual happiness. This questionnaire has 29 self-report statements for responses on a 6-point Likert scale. A shortened 8-item version is also available.

Participants use a 1–6 scale to report how much they agree with 29 items, where 1 indicates the strongest disagreement possible and six, the strongest agreement.

It includes questions on happiness, such as the following:

I have very warm feelings towards almost everyone.

There is a gap between what I would like to do and what I have done.

I do not have a particular sense of meaning and purpose in my life.

